

Milestones of Growth: 5, 10, 21, and 42

My dad forced me to run when I was around grade 5. Oh, I hated that first 5K on a treadmill at 9 PM, right before my bedtime. But that was not the point. My house had 5 floors, and the room with the treadmill was on the 5th floor, along with other small gym equipment. My small bedroom was on the 3rd floor, and I just wanted to tell you that I was not afraid to spend 40 minutes running on my machine as a kid, but it was the trip to the 5th floor at night that prevented me from enjoying the run. That 4th floor was nightmare fuel. I was still scared of ghosts, and back then, that 4th floor had 2 rooms on the side that were completely pitch-dark, and I had to go up and down all by myself. I remembered running up and down, and once I even broke my leg running down the stairs too fast.

By grade 10, I fully embraced a healthy lifestyle. During a time when everyone was staying home, I turned my space into a personal sanctuary for growth. I loved the routine of waking up at 6 AM to stretch and prepare for the day. Training in the warm Hanoi afternoons taught me resilience and how to find energy in any environment. This was the period I achieved my first 10 km run, following a dedicated 5 km to 10 km progression. It was an empowering time where I discovered boxing as a way to channel my energy and improve my focus, helping me develop a more positive way to express my feelings.

One day, things just exploded. My grandpa was annoyed about something and pushed it all onto me. I kept pushing myself to the limit and eventually blacked out during a deadlift. My dad bought me a chocolate bar after that. Luckily, it did not leave a scar, since I fell face down and only cracked my glasses.

At that point, I did not really have a guide for healthily processing these feelings. There is a good chance that I still do not, but I am getting better at it. That was when I started writing down small thoughts in my Notes app, capturing the moments instead of losing them or letting them run free in my mind.

In 2024, I reached a new peak by running 21 km. It was amazing how quickly my endurance improved with consistent effort. As I approached my 21st birthday in 2025, I felt a renewed sense of purpose. I even attempted my first 42 km in Seattle. Although that first attempt was a learning experience where I prioritized my long-term health by stopping early, it was a wonderful day spent with family. We shared a fantastic meal afterward, celebrating the progress I had made and the lessons learned on the road.

During my mid-term break, I returned to Seattle and successfully completed the 42 km distance! With "Timeless" playing in my ears, I felt a deep sense of internal strength and determination. Crossing that finish line in under six hours was an incredible feeling of personal triumph. It wasn't about the pace; it was about the dedication to the goal. I even had some lighthearted interactions with locals that made the day even more memorable. After finishing, I enjoyed a well-deserved rest and a celebratory dinner with my cousin, feeling completely fulfilled.

This marathon journey is a perfect metaphor for my 20s. With persistence and a positive mindset, every challenge becomes an opportunity to succeed. By the summer, I ran the distance again and achieved a personal best of 5:30. I know that by keeping a bright outlook and continuing to move forward, the path ahead is full of wonderful possibilities.